Sorry

By Dori Appel

(Theresa Barnes, a woman in her late thirties, speaks from a ward in a mental hospital, addressing the audience as though speaking to fellow patients. Throughout the monologue, moments of forthrightness and humor vie with those of confusion, despair, and rage.)

THERESA: **(Pg 3-6)** Two o'clock. Free time on the funny farm, everybody, and I suggest you spend it with me. It will do you more good than watching the soaps, more good than the Tuesday afternoon sing-a-long, more good than chair caning class. Chair caning! Where did they think up that one? We're mentally ill, not blind!

Hey, you ever think about how you got crazy? Or do you just imagine that the little gears inside your brain just somehow jumped the track? I think about it a lot. That's one thing about being in this place, you get some time to think. And I'll tell you something-I believe being crazy may be the final and perfect expression of what we've been trained for all our lives.

Think of it this way-what's the thing we say the most? Come on, girlfriends, help me out. *(She points.)* Right! "I'm sorry." Whatever it is, whoever's upset, it's something for you to apologize for. You drank the last Pepsi, or the dog peed on the rug, or your husband lost his keys, or your kid didn't get invited to somebody's party, or it rained or it didn't, and it seems like you ought to say, "I'm sorry."

INTRODUCTION

Therapy gives you more control over your life. You become more conscious of your self and your behavior. You become more honest with yourself. You begin to take the driver's seat in your life and take control - rather than be controlled by other people or events. Your personal power increases. You become aware that you have choices. You run the show and no longer have to feel Sorry for everything that happens.

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THERESA: And what's everybody say to us when we're upset? *(She points.)* You got it-"It's all in your head." If they hurt your feelings, you're too sensitive-it's all in your head. If they make you mad, they didn't mean anything-it's all in your head. If you get scared, there's nothing to be afraid of-it's all in your head. And the backaches and night sweats and stomach and skin problems that don't ring the right bells on the medical testing machines, they're in your head, too. *(Beat)*

And so now we're crazy, and everything bothers us, and it's all in our heads, and we're really sorry to boot!

(In a reproving and slightly condescending voice) "It's a sickness like any other sickness, Mrs. Barnes. There's nothing to be ashamed of." (In her own voice) That's the social worker, who has, of course, already read every humiliating detail of why you need to be here. No shame, no blame, and no reason to think that anyone stuck you in this place just to shut you up. *(In the reproving and reasoning voice)* "The hospital is just a little time-out."

(In her own voice) Sure, why not? I put my kids in timeout sometimes. When they're bad. And I tell them it's for their own good. You put the bad kid in the room and you say, "You have to stay there until you can behave yourself." And then you shut the door. *(Beat)* Stay right there, crazy lady, until you can remember how to be . . . a lady. The job description's pinned to the back of the closed door.

But somewhere there's a bad little girl who isn't afraid of being left alone in that dark room. She'd just sit there, and when her husband came-oh no, that's no good. *(She laughs.)* Little girls don't have husbands, do they? *(Beat)* Woe be to the one who does not emerge from the closed room remorseful, who will not say "Sorry" when they finally let her out. They've got the evidence: the buckets of tears, the meals not cooked, kids not cared for, husbands suffering from insufficient marital relations. *(Beat)* Evidence. Evidence. The groove worn in the mattress during the sleeping days, the varnish worn off the floor during the nonsleeping, pacing nights. The razor blades, the empty bottles of pills. *(Beat)* Sorry. I'm sorry. Love, honor, obey, and be sorry.

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You want to know why they sent me here? Just because I stopped being sorry and started getting- Well, it was clear that I wasn't myself. A woman in her right mind doesn't scream like a banshee at the drop of a hat, and break every dish in the kitchen cabinets, and cut all the cords off the household appliances. My husband was annoyed, of course. But he worries about me, he wants me to get well-and the staff is very encouraging. The very first day I was here, I was sitting on the bed and watching my sad-looking feet hanging down, and that nurse with the big, round, smiley face came in with a lunch tray. She gave me an extra big smile as she set it down and told me how I was going to be back on my feet real soon. I knew what she meant. *(As the nurse, with the voice of an evil witch)* "You're going to be cooking and cleaning and jumping to meet everybody's whim and demand before you've even caught your breath! The moment your insurance runs out, you're gone!" *(As herself, rather matter-of fact)* After I threw the custard from the lunch tray in her face, I learned about a new version of time-out: The Quiet Room. Nothing in it but a mattress on the floor. While I was locked up in there, I thought about what I'd done. It wasn't nice. So, I wrote "Sorry" on the wall with my own crap.

Then on the weekend my husband Sandy came, looking some combination of miserable and guilty, and he told me how he and the kids missed me and wanted me home. And I really was sorry. I wasn't angry anymore, and I cried all the rest of the day, and everybody here started being much nicer to me. When the doctor came to see me, he told me that a lot of women these days are angry about their roles. "Well," I said, "Maybe they've been given a stale one."

He kept on talking, of course, but I didn't listen. I was thinking about the Quiet Room when they locked me in there. Only it was different. It wasn't that bare room with the mattress that I was thinking about. It was a little girl's bed room, all frilly blue and white. *(She drifts into her fantasy.)* A little girl is being sent to her room for being bad. She can't come out until she's sorry. They close the door, and as soon as they're gone, she hops off the bed and crouches down so she can see under it. She picks up the blue organdy ruffle that matches

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the curtains and pillow shams that her Mommy and Daddy got her because she's their special little girl, and she reaches under there and hauls out a big old ax! She runs her finger over the blade carefully, just to make sure it's sharp. And then, SMASH! There go all the nice storybooks, and the dollhouse with its tiny furniture, and SMASH! There goes the white painted dresser holding her neatly folded clothes, and the bed posts off the bed. And SMASH! She chops down that closed door and she bursts out free! And she tells everyone, "I'm not sorry! Not one bit!" *(Shaken, she returns to the present and regains control though she is still in the grip of strong emotion. She glances at her watch.)* Free hour's just about up, isn't it? That person from the community college is supposed to come and tell us about all their adult noncredit courses. I doubt that they've got the one I want. What I want is a course on the social history of apology. I want to know the origins of the word "Sorry." That's what I want to study, and I want it for credit. Full credit.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Dori Appel
Book: Even More Monologues for Women by Women (Pgs 3-6)
ISBN: 978-0325002477
Publisher: Heinemann
Date (Month/Year): March 2001

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier – MS
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

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